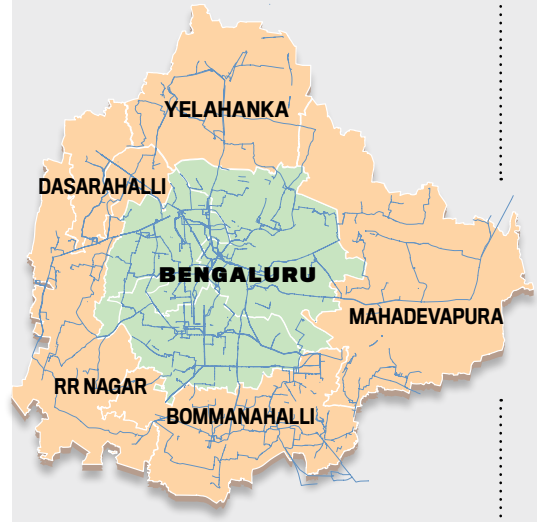


RUNNING ON EMPTY A drinking water queue at a 'water ATM' in Rajarajeshwari Nagar, S-W Bengaluru, Mar. 3

Photographs by JITHENDRA M

THE SHAPE OF WATER



Borewell-dependent area
'Core area' which has Cauvery water supply
BWSSB waterlines

14 million: Population of Bengaluru

2,600 million litres a day (MLD): Demand for water in Bengaluru

1,450 MLD: Cauvery water supply to Bengaluru City

1,250 MLD: Supply from borewells. Number of private borewells: **4,50,000** Number of public borewells: **14,781**. Estimated **25-30** per cent deficit in water yield from borewells

200-300 MLD: Shortfall of water the city faces

₹556 crore: Funds set aside to manage drinking water supply

itself. However, Cauvery water connections are available only to the city's core part. The rest of the city depends on borewells—of which there are over 4,60,000, private as well as public—which supply 1,250 MLD of its water needs. And, as Karnataka deputy chief minister D.K. Shivakumar pointed out, about 50 per cent of the city's public borewells have run dry. While public borewells constitute less than five per cent of total borewells in the city, private borewells, which form the majority, have also started running dry. Officials estimate there is a deficit of 25-30 per cent in water yield from borewells, leading to a shortfall of 200-300 MLD.

According to an analysis by Water, Environment, Land and Livelihoods (WELL) Labs, groundwater levels have dipped by over 100 per cent between 2022 and 2023 in some peripheral areas in the northwest and south Bengaluru—the former also overlapping with zones without piped water and totally dependent on borewells (see above map). Add contiguous zones that have seen at least a 50 per cent dip, and that's a lot of Bengaluru going thirsty. "There's no shortage in Cauvery water," says Ram Prasath Manohar V., chairman of the Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board (BWSSB). "Borewell water is the gap that needs to be bridged."

> Treated water forms part of an innovative plan: **to recharge aquifers** as well as for industrial and commercial use

The shortage of water is unleashing panic—apartments are rationing water, industries are bracing for a tough season ahead. "People are expecting the worst," says Manas Das, president, Outer Ring Road Companies Association, which represents major IT and banking companies on a 17-kilometre tech corridor in southeast Bengaluru where roughly half a million employees go to work in swanky campuses. "The advice we are giving everyone is to be prudent in water usage," says Das. "If we don't prepare upfront, it's going to be almost a business continuity scenario." That is, an emergency situation where businesses keep alive only critical functions.

The government is putting stringent measures in place. The BWSSB has put a Rs 5,000 penalty on those using potable water supplied by the agency for other purposes, such as washing cars or watering gardens. And wary of 'surge pricing' by private water tankers, the civic authority Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP) has capped rates at Rs 600 for 6,000 litres up to a distance of 5 km and Rs 750 for up to 10 km. Last month, private water tankers had hiked prices by 30-100 per cent, according to a survey conducted by the Bangalore Apartments' Federation (BAF). The signs of an impending supply disruption were evident, points out Vikram Rai, general secretary of BAF. "People had started reporting